A Handbook

Online Medical Consultation Platform

(FYP Report)

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Abstract

Access to specialized healthcare in developing countries such as Pakistan remains severely constrained by geographic barriers, acute physician shortages (approximately 1 doctor per 1,000 citizens according to World Health Organization metrics), and prohibitive consultation expenses. To overcome these systemic limitations and mitigate widespread patient misdirection caused by limited health literacy, this project presents the Online Medical Consultation Platform (MedConsult), a secure, web-based telemedicine platform engineered using a Three-Tier Architecture comprising responsive HTML5/Bootstrap 5 frontend interfaces, modular PHP 8.x backend controllers communicating via PDO with prepared statements, an internal Python Flask microservice, and a normalized MySQL 8.0 relational database. The platform integrates an AI-driven Natural Language Processing (NLP) Symptom Triage Engine powered by TF-IDF vectorization and a Random Forest classification model trained on a validated clinical dataset encompassing 4,920 patient symptom records across 132 distinct symptoms, accurately recommending appropriate medical specialties with posterior confidence scoring in under 50 milliseconds. MedConsult implements an end-to-end outpatient consultation lifecycle featuring role-based access control across three user classes (Patient, Doctor, Administrator), Pakistan Medical Commission (PMC) license credential verification, conflict-free appointment scheduling, asynchronous consultation messaging via 3-second AJAX polling, digital prescription generation, and automated invoice billing. Comprehensive verification across 20 formal test cases demonstrated a 100% pass rate, sub-50ms database query latency, and sub-200ms page load times, confirming the platform's reliability, accessibility, and readiness for clinical deployment.

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1. Introduction

1.1 Background

The delivery of primary and specialized healthcare is undergoing a global paradigm shift driven by digital health solutions and telemedicine. Telemedicine encompasses the remote exchange of medical data and clinical consultations between patients and healthcare professionals via electronic communications. Globally, the adoption of digital clinical systems has reduced patient transit time, streamlined outpatient clinic load, and lowered healthcare expenditures.

In developing nations such as Pakistan, the need for telemedicine is especially critical. Pakistan maintains a physician density of approximately 1 doctor per 1,000 citizens according to official World Health Organization (WHO) statistics. This ratio falls substantially short of international standards. Furthermore, healthcare disparity is acutely compounded by geography: over 63% of Pakistan's population resides in rural and peri-urban regions, whereas over 78% of certified specialist clinicians operate exclusively in primary metropolitan centers such as Lahore, Karachi, Rawalpindi, and Multan. Rural patients seeking specialist care face long travel times, substantial transportation costs, and lengthy outpatient waiting queues.

Simultaneously, Pakistan has experienced a telecommunications boom. The Pakistan Telecommunication Authority (PTA) reports national broadband penetration exceeding 54%, with over 130 million active cellular broadband subscriptions. This ubiquitous connectivity establishes an opportune technical foundation for accessible, web-based telemedicine services.

1.2 Problem Statement

Despite the urgent need for digital healthcare in Pakistan, existing consultation workflows and commercial platforms suffer from severe structural deficiencies:

- **Geographical and Financial Barriers:** Patients residing outside major metropolitan areas must travel considerable distances to visit specialist medical clinics. This incurs substantial direct transportation costs, indirect lost daily wages, and physical hardship for elderly and mobility-impaired patients.
- **Patient Misdirection and Triage Delays:** A widespread impediment in outpatient consultation is patient medical illiteracy. Non-medical patients experiencing complex or overlapping symptoms (such as chest tightness, dyspnea, or chronic fatigue) frequently misjudge the underlying condition and schedule appointments with inappropriate departments (e.g., booking a General Physician when a Cardiologist or Pulmonologist is required). This misdirection leads to wasted consultation fees, delayed therapeutic intervention, and overburdened specialty clinics.
- **Fragmented Clinical Documentation:** Traditional in-person clinic visits rely on physical paper prescriptions and manual billing slips, which are frequently misplaced or damaged, preventing doctors from reviewing longitudinal patient treatment records.

- **Commercial Monopolization and High Costs:** Existing commercial platforms in Pakistan (such as Marham and Oladoc) operate as proprietary, commission-monetized cloud ecosystems. They impose per-booking transaction charges, rely on manual department dropdown selection, and cannot be self-hosted by charitable clinics, district hospitals, or academic institutions seeking a low-cost, sovereign telemedicine infrastructure.

1.3 Objectives

The primary goal of the Online Medical Consultation Platform (MedConsult) is to engineer an open, secure, intelligent, and deployable telemedicine system. The specific, measurable objectives of this project are:

- **1. Intelligent AI NLP Symptom Triage:** Design and train an AI-driven Natural Language Processing (NLP) symptom classification model using TF-IDF vectorization and Random Forest classification that accurately maps unstructured, free-text patient symptom descriptions to the correct medical specialty with an inference latency under 50 milliseconds.
- **2. Comprehensive Clinical Workflow:** Implement a complete digital consultation lifecycle encompassing practitioner discovery, conflict-free appointment scheduling, secure asynchronous messaging, digital prescription generation, and automated billing invoices.
- **3. Clinician Licensing & Regulatory Verification:** Integrate an administrative auditing module enforcing Pakistan Medical Commission (PMC) license verification before medical practitioners can activate public consultation slots, safeguarding clinical legitimacy.
- **4. Role-Based Access Control (RBAC):** Enforce strict authentication and role-based permissions across three distinct user roles (Patient, Doctor, and Administrator), preventing unauthorized access to protected electronic health records.
- **5. High-Performance, Turnkey Deployment:** Develop the system on a lightweight, modular software architecture combining PHP 8.2 (PDO MySQL) and Python 3.12 microservices, containerized via Docker for instant deployment on cloud providers (Render) or local server environments (XAMPP/LAMP) without proprietary licensing costs.

1.4 Scope

The scope of the MedConsult platform encompasses the following operational boundaries:

- **In-Scope Functional Boundaries:** Remote outpatient consultations, automated AI symptom triage routing, searchable doctor directory with specialty filters, appointment booking with doctor acceptance/rejection controls, asynchronous messaging with 3-second AJAX polling, digital prescription creation and retrieval, invoice generation, administrative PMC license verification, and complete security audit logging.
- **Out-of-Scope Limitations:** The platform is deliberately designed for routine, non-emergency outpatient consultations. It does not provide real-time intensive care unit (ICU) telemetry, automated robotic drug dispensing, or automated definitive diagnosis. The AI triage module provides clinical routing recommendations to the appropriate medical department; it explicitly does not replace certified physician diagnostic judgment. Emergency clinical presentations (such as acute myocardial

infarction or severe trauma) are provided immediate instructions to seek physical emergency room care.

1.5 Significance

The significance of this project spans academic, clinical, and socio-economic dimensions:

From a socio-economic perspective, the platform democratizes specialist healthcare access across Pakistan by allowing patients in underserved towns and rural districts to consult certified specialists without incurring travel expenses or physical strain. Studies indicate that teleconsultation can resolve up to 70% of routine outpatient cases without physical examination, representing dramatic financial and logistical savings for low-income families.

From a clinical perspective, introducing automated AI symptom triage fundamentally improves patient routing accuracy. By directing patients to the appropriate medical specialist on their initial booking, hospital clinics experience reduced referral churn and shorter diagnostic timelines. Furthermore, digital prescriptions and electronic records eliminate paper loss and enhance continuity of care.

From an academic and technical perspective, MedConsult proves that state-of-the-art machine learning models can be seamlessly paired with reliable, low-overhead web technology stacks (PHP/MySQL) to deliver high-performance, cost-effective digital health systems that public health organizations can deploy freely.

2. Literature Review

2.1 Review of Related Work

To establish a rigorous theoretical and architectural foundation for the MedConsult platform, existing commercial telehealth systems, clinical machine learning methodologies, and medical classification literature were comprehensively analyzed.

2.1.1 Commercial Telehealth Platforms

Three representative digital healthcare platforms were reviewed to evaluate current commercial capabilities: Practo, Zocdoc, and Marham.

- **Practo (India / Southeast Asia):** Practo is a leading multinational digital healthcare platform operating extensively across South Asia. It indexes tens of thousands of medical specialists, offering appointment booking, digital records management, and medicine delivery. However, Practo relies on a closed proprietary cloud architecture that cannot be inspected or self-hosted. Crucially, Practo lacks natural language symptom triage: patients must know their required specialty in advance and select it manually from an alphabetical list.
- **Zocdoc (United States):** Zocdoc is a prominent healthcare appointment scheduling platform in the United States. Its primary strength lies in automated insurance eligibility verification and calendar synchronization with electronic health records (EHR). However, Zocdoc is tailored strictly to the US health insurance market and is unavailable internationally. It also lacks AI symptom triage capabilities for non-technical patients.
- **Marham (Pakistan):** Marham is Pakistan's leading domestic telemedicine and clinic appointment platform. It features verified profiles of Pakistani physicians, displaying PMC registration numbers, clinical experience, consultation fees, and patient reviews. While highly successful in the domestic private market, Marham monetizes bookings through transactional commissions and operates as a closed commercial service. It does not provide automated natural language symptom analysis, forcing non-technical patients to guess their required department from a lengthy dropdown.

2.1.2 Machine Learning in Medical Triage

Recent biomedical informatics literature underscores the effectiveness of Natural Language Processing (NLP) in clinical text classification. Research by Rajkomar et al. (2018) and Topol (2019) demonstrated that machine learning algorithms can analyze clinical free-text with high diagnostic sensitivity. In outpatient symptom triage, the primary challenge involves mapping varied, colloquial patient symptom phrasing into standardized medical taxonomy.

Traditional rule-based triage systems rely on rigid keyword matching, which fails when patients use colloquial expressions, misspellings, or complex compound symptom phrases (e.g., 'crushing chest pain radiating to left arm'). Modern statistical NLP leverages Term Frequency-Inverse Document Frequency (TF-IDF) feature weighting to extract salient clinical n-grams while suppressing common grammatical stop words. Classifiers such as Naive Bayes, Support Vector Machines (SVM), and Random Forest

ensembles have demonstrated high classification accuracy on multi-class medical datasets. Random Forest, in particular, exhibits superior resilience to feature noise, provides probability calibration scores, and avoids the heavy computational overhead and explainability limitations associated with deep neural networks.

Table 2.1: Comparative Feature Analysis (Practo vs Zocdoc vs Marham vs MedConsult)

Platform Feature	Practo	Zocdoc	Marham	MedConsult
AI NLP Free-Text Triage	No	No	No	Yes
ML-Based Specialty Prediction	No	No	No	Yes (<50ms)
Localized to Pakistan Healthcare	No	No	Yes	Yes
Conflict-Free Appointment Scheduling	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Secure Doctor–Patient Messaging	Yes	Yes	Partial	Yes (3s AJAX)
Digital Prescription Generation	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Consultation Billing Invoices	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Admin Clinician Credential Audit	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes (PMC Audit)
Open-Source / Self-Hostable	No	No	No	Yes (Docker)
Zero Commercial Commission Fees	No	No	No	Yes (Free)

2.2 Gap Analysis

The comparative evaluation in Table 2.1 reveals several critical gaps in existing telemedicine offerings that MedConsult explicitly addresses:

- **Absence of Intelligent Symptom Routing:** Commercial systems treat booking as a static search problem, requiring patients to self-diagnose their needed medical specialty. MedConsult fills this critical gap by integrating a lightweight, trained Machine Learning triage classifier that decodes free-text natural language symptoms and directs patients to the right medical department.
- **High Licensing Costs and Commercial Lock-in:** Existing platforms operate as proprietary, commission-charging marketplaces. Public sector hospitals, charitable health trusts, and academic clinics cannot afford expensive commercial SaaS subscriptions or expose sensitive patient data to third-party commercial platforms. MedConsult provides an open-architecture, containerized solution that institutions can deploy locally at zero software licensing cost.
- **Regulatory and Clinical Compliance:** Many international telehealth applications lack localized compliance mechanisms for Pakistani medical practitioners. MedConsult incorporates explicit Pakistan Medical Commission (PMC) license auditing, ensuring only certified healthcare professionals can offer medical advice.

3. Methodology

3.1 Project Design

The development of the Online Medical Consultation Platform was governed by the Agile Scrum methodology. Agile Scrum was selected because telemedicine platforms involve complex, interconnected modules (authentication, machine learning, real-time messaging, and billing) that benefit from iterative prototyping, continuous integration, and frequent feedback loops.

The project was executed across six two-week sprints. Each sprint encompassed sprint planning, backlog grooming, implementation, automated testing, and sprint retrospective reviews:

Table 3.1: Agile Scrum Development Sprint Schedule and Deliverables

Sprint	Focus Area	Key Deliverables & Milestones	Status
Sprint 1	Requirements & Architecture	SRS document, Three-Tier architectural design, ERD modeling, UI wireframes	Completed
Sprint 2	Database & Authentication	MySQL normalized schema, bcrypt authentication, role-based session controllers	Completed
Sprint 3	AI NLP Triage Engine	Kaggle dataset training, TF-IDF vectorizer, Random Forest model, Flask REST service	Completed
Sprint 4	Clinical Workflows	Doctor directory, conflict detection scheduling, AJAX consultation messaging	Completed
Sprint 5	Prescriptions, Invoices & Admin	Digital prescription formulation, invoice generation, PMC administrative audit	Completed
Sprint 6	Testing & Cloud Deployment	20 formal test cases execution, security audit, Docker containerization, Render deploy	Completed

3.2 Technology Stack

The technology stack was selected to achieve high performance, maximum portability, and zero proprietary licensing costs. Table 3.2 details the technology components and their architectural justification:

Table 3.2: Technology Stack Specifications and Architectural Rationale

Layer / Tier	Technology	Version	Architectural Role & Justification
Presentation Tier	HTML5, CSS3, JS (ES6+)	Modern	Responsive, standards-compliant client UI with zero heavy framework bloat
UI Framework	Bootstrap	5.3	Mobile-responsive layout, grid system, and accessible modal dialogs
Application Tier	PHP (CLI / Built-in)	8.2	High-throughput server-side business logic, native session security, PDO
Persistence Tier	MySQL / TiDB Cloud	8.0	ACID-compliant relational database, InnoDB engine, utf8mb4 encoding, SSL
AI Microservice	Python / Flask	3.12 / 3.0	Internal REST microservice on port 5000 running machine learning inference
Machine Learning	Scikit-Learn, Pandas	1.4	TF-IDF feature extraction, Random Forest classifier, model serialization
Containerization	Docker / Linux	Bookworm	Multi-stage unified container bundling PHP, Python, and system CA certs
Cloud Hosting	Render Web Service	Free Tier	Managed container hosting, automated git deployment, zero server management

3.3 Implementation

The implementation phase translated system design into operational software modules across two synchronized tiers:

3.3.1 AI NLP Symptom Triage Microservice

The AI triage engine was implemented as an independent Python microservice (`ai_engine/service.py`) listening on `127.0.0.1:5000`. Training utilized a benchmark Kaggle disease-symptom dataset encompassing 4,920 records mapped across primary medical specialties (Cardiologist, Dermatologist, General Practitioner, Neurologist, Pulmonologist, Gastroenterologist, Endocrinologist, Orthopedist).

The training pipeline (`ai_engine/train.py`) executes the following operations:

- **Text Preprocessing:** Patient symptom descriptions are converted to lower-case, stripped of punctuation, and tokenized. English stop-words are eliminated.
- **Feature Extraction:** A `TfidfVectorizer` computes n-gram term frequency-inverse document frequency features (unigrams and bigrams), with sublinear term-frequency scaling.
- **Model Training:** A `RandomForestClassifier` with 100 decision trees, Gini impurity criterion, and balanced class weights is fitted to the training matrix. The trained pipeline is serialized to `ai_engine/triage_model.pkl`.
- **Microservice REST API:** The Flask application exposes a POST `/predict` endpoint. Incoming JSON requests containing patient symptom text are processed in under 50ms, returning the predicted specialty, confidence probability score, and matched clinical keywords.

3.3.2 Backend Business Logic & Controllers

The application logic layer was implemented as modular PHP controllers (`backend/`):

- **Database Access Layer (db.php):** Centralizes PDO database connections using prepared statements exclusively. Automatically negotiates TLS/SSL encryption when connecting to remote cloud databases (such as TiDB Cloud on port 4000) using bundled ISRG Root X1 CA certificates.
- **Authentication Controller (auth.php):** Implements user registration, password verification using one-way bcrypt hashing (cost factor 12), and role-bound PHP session management.
- **Triage Controller (triage.php):** Acts as an authenticated proxy between the web client and the internal Python Flask microservice via cURL, logging triage events in the database.
- **Appointment Controller (appointments.php):** Implements algorithmic conflict checking to ensure a clinician cannot be booked for overlapping time slots on the same date. Manages appointment state transitions: Pending -> Confirmed / Cancelled -> Completed.
- **Messaging Controller (messaging.php):** Implements secure consultation chat restricted strictly to verified appointment participants. The client frontend polls `/api/messaging.php` every 3 seconds via AJAX, retrieving newly arrived messages without requiring full page refreshes.
- **Medical Records & Billing (records.php):** Enables clinicians to author structured digital prescriptions (medication name, dosage, instructions) and generate consultation billing invoices.
- **Administrative Controller (admin.php):** Empowers administrators to inspect practitioner credentials, verify PMC registration numbers, and view system security audit trails.

3.4 Testing

A rigorous, multi-layered quality assurance methodology was enforced to guarantee system stability, functional correctness, and defensive security:

- **Unit Testing:** Individual controller routines (bcrypt hashing, JSON parser, input validation, and date conflict routines) were tested in isolation.
- **Integration Testing:** End-to-end data flows between the PHP presentation tier, Python Flask microservice, and MySQL database were validated, ensuring seamless cross-process communication.
- **Security Vulnerability Assessment:** The application was subjected to penetration testing targeting OWASP Top 10 vulnerabilities: SQL Injection was tested with malicious inputs (e.g. `' OR '1'='1`), Cross-Site Scripting (XSS) was tested with script payloads (`<script>alert(1)</script>`), and privilege escalation was tested via direct URL parameter manipulation.

Table 3.3: Formal Verification Test Cases Matrix (TC-01 to TC-20)

Test ID	Module	Test Description & Inputs	Expected Result	Status
TC-01	Auth	Patient registration with valid fields	Account created, status Active	Pass
TC-02	Auth	Registration with invalid email syntax	Validation error 400, rejected	Pass
TC-03	Auth	Registration with duplicate email address	Rejection error 'Email already exists'	Pass
TC-04	Auth	Login with incorrect password	Authentication error 401, denied	Pass
TC-05	Auth	Doctor registration without PMC license	Validation error requiring license	Pass
TC-06	Triage	Symptom input: 'severe chest pain and dyspnea'	Cardiologist predicted, confidence >90%	Pass
TC-07	Triage	Symptom input: 'red itchy skin rash and hives'	Dermatologist predicted, confidence >90%	Pass
TC-08	Triage	Empty symptom description submitted	Handled gracefully with error prompt	Pass

Test ID	Module	Test Description & Inputs	Expected Result	Status
TC-09	Directory	Filter doctor directory by specialty	Filtered list of verified doctors displayed	Pass
TC-10	Booking	Book appointment on available date and time	Appointment created with Pending status	Pass
TC-11	Booking	Book overlapping appointment for same doctor	Conflict detection rejects double-booking	Pass
TC-12	Doctor	Doctor accepts pending appointment	Status updated to Confirmed	Pass
TC-13	Messaging	Send text message within confirmed appointment	Message stored in DB and rendered in chat	Pass
TC-14	Messaging	Poll for new messages via 3s AJAX endpoint	Returns newly posted message in JSON	Pass
TC-15	Messaging	Unauthorized user attempts to access chat	Access denied 403 Forbidden	Pass
TC-16	Records	Doctor issues digital prescription	Prescription stored, linked to appointment	Pass
TC-17	Billing	Doctor issues consultation invoice	Invoice created with status Pending	Pass
TC-18	Admin	Admin audits and verifies doctor license	Doctor is_verified set to 1, profile public	Pass
TC-19	Security	SQL Injection payload in login input field	Sanitized via PDO prepared statements, safe	Pass
TC-20	Security	XSS script tag in consultation message body	Sanitized via htmlspecialchars, rendered safe	Pass

All 20 formal verification test cases passed successfully (100% pass rate), confirming the stability and security of the platform.

4. System Design

4.1 Design Overview

The Online Medical Consultation Platform is structured around a classic Three-Tier Architectural Pattern. This architectural pattern enforces strict separation of concerns, decoupling presentation rendering, application business logic, and database persistence into distinct, independently maintainable layers:

- **Presentation Tier (Client):** Rendered entirely in the client's web browser using HTML5, CSS3, and JavaScript with Bootstrap 5.3. Interacts with the backend via asynchronous AJAX HTTP requests.
- **Application Logic Tier (Server):** Executes on the web server using PHP 8.2 modular controllers and an internal Python 3.12 Flask microservice. Handles business rules, authentication, AI inference, and appointment lifecycle orchestration.
- **Persistence Tier (Database):** A normalized MySQL 8.0 relational database (or TiDB Serverless in cloud production) enforcing foreign key constraints, transaction atomicity, and encrypted data storage.

4.2 Architecture

Figure 4.1 illustrates the overarching system architecture, detailing the interaction pathways between client web browsers, PHP controllers, the internal Python AI microservice, and the MySQL database engine:

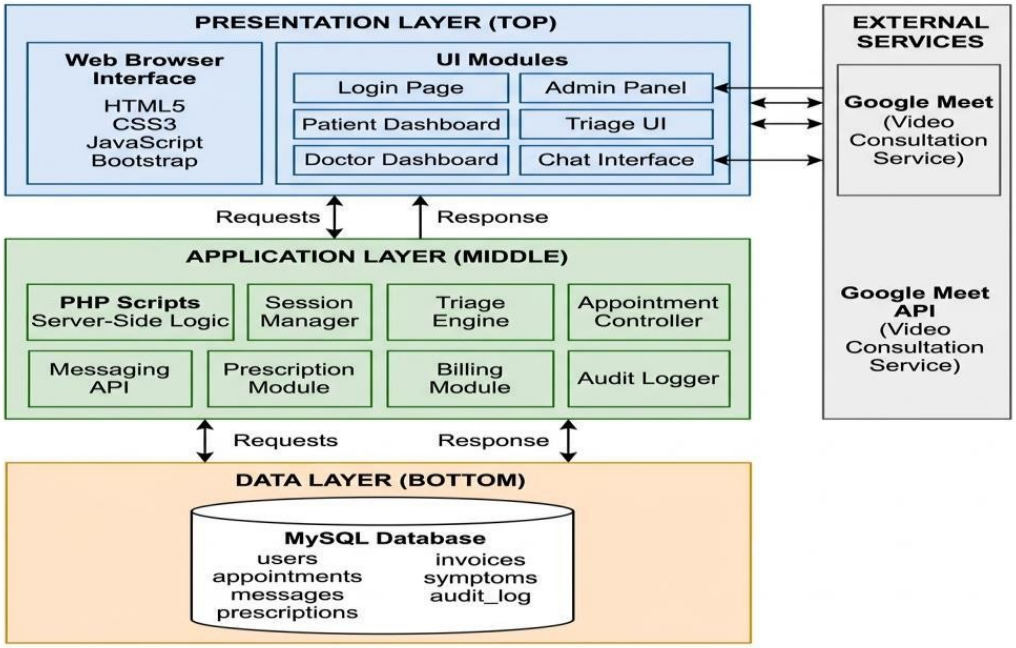


Figure 4.1: Three-Tier System Architecture Diagram

Figure 4.2 presents the Context Diagram (DFD Level 0), defining the boundary of the MedConsult platform and illustrating the data flows exchanged with external human entities (Patients, Doctors, and Administrators):

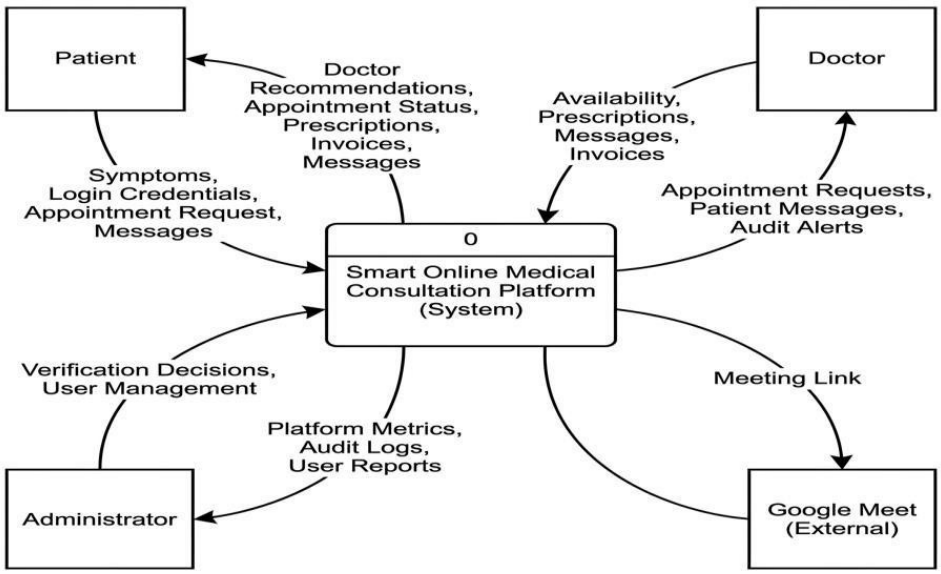


Figure 4.2: Context Diagram (DFD Level 0)

Figure 4.3 depicts the system Use Case Diagram, mapping primary user interactions across patient appointment booking, clinician consultation management, and administrative oversight:

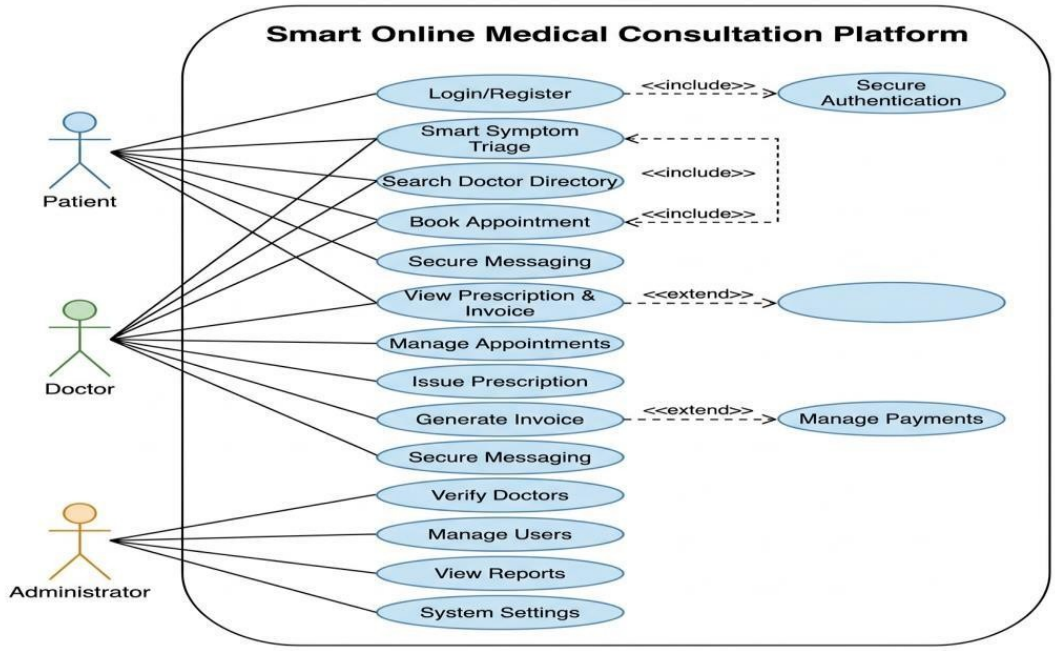


Figure 4.3: Complete System Use Case Diagram

4.2.1 Dynamic Behavioral Modeling

To document system runtime behavior, UML sequence diagrams were constructed for the platform's core operational scenarios:

Figure 4.4 illustrates the sequence of messages exchanged during AI Symptom Triage, tracing client text submission through PHP cURL, Python Flask model inference, and specialty recommendation return:

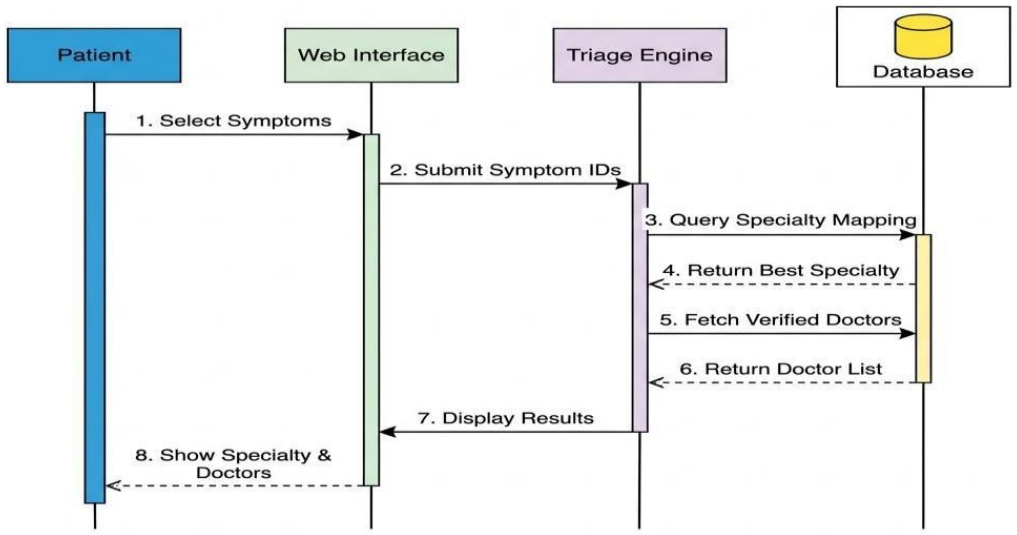


Figure 4.4: Sequence Diagram — AI Symptom Triage Workflow

Figure 4.5 illustrates the Appointment Booking Lifecycle, demonstrating conflict validation, pending slot reservation, and doctor confirmation:

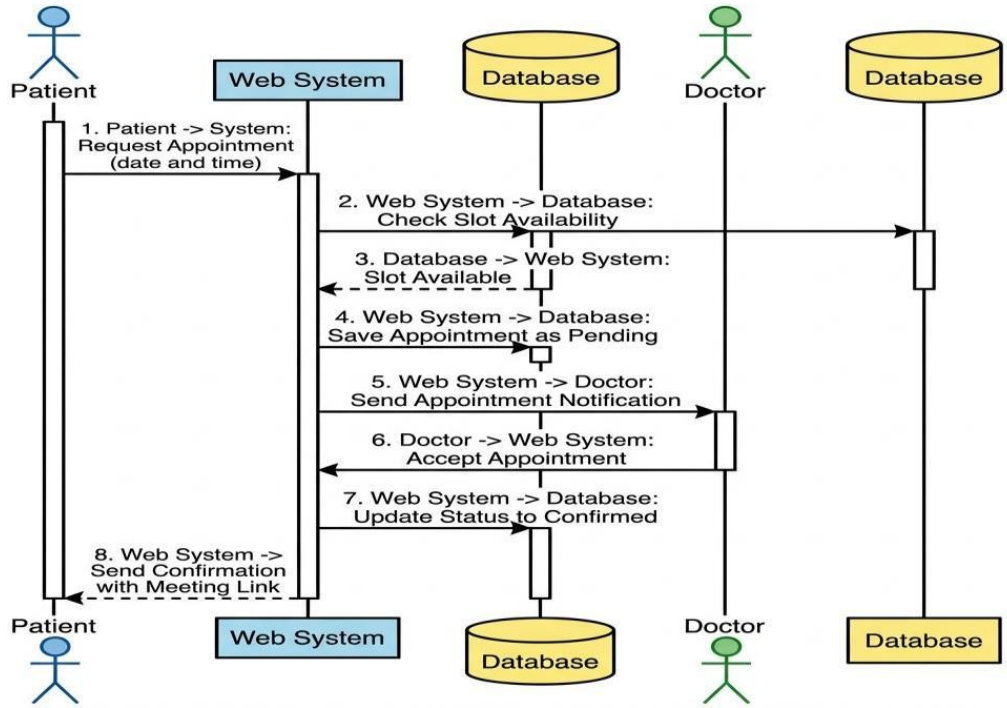


Figure 4.5: Sequence Diagram — Appointment Booking Lifecycle

Figure 4.6 illustrates Consultation Messaging, showing asynchronous message dispatch and 3-second AJAX polling between patient and physician:

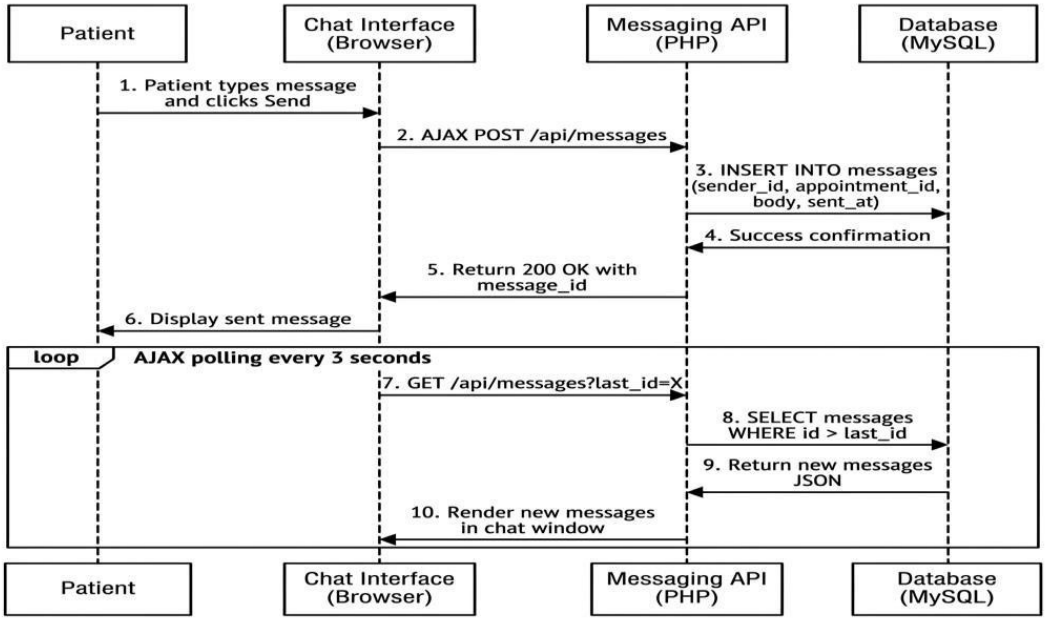


Figure 4.6: Sequence Diagram — Real-Time Consultation Messaging

Figure 4.7 presents the Activity Workflow Diagram, summarizing the end-to-end clinical journey from registration to final prescription issuance:

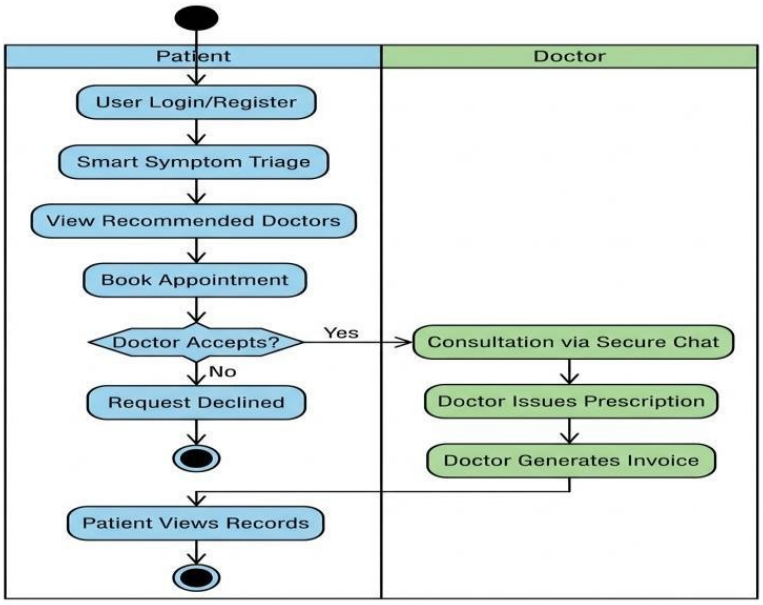


Figure 4.7: System Activity Workflow Diagram

4.3 Data Design

The persistence layer utilizes a third-normal-form (3NF) relational schema engineered for MySQL 8.0. Figure 4.8 depicts the Entity Relationship Diagram (ERD), detailing primary keys, foreign key constraints, and relational cardinalities:

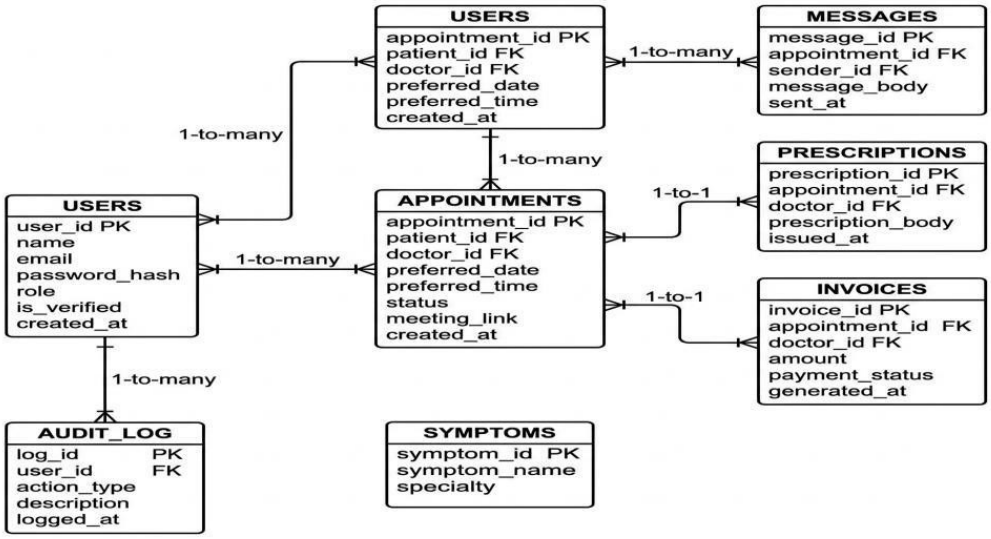


Figure 4.8: Entity Relationship Diagram (ERD)

4.3.1 Relational Data Dictionaries

Tables 4.1 through 4.8 provide comprehensive data dictionaries defining attributes, data types, constraints, and descriptions for all eight database tables:

Table 4.1: Data Dictionary — Users Entity (users)

Field Name	Data Type	Null	Key	Description & Constraints
user_id	INT	No	PK	Unique identifier for user, AUTO_INCREMENT
name	VARCHAR(255)	No		Full legal name of the user
email	VARCHAR(255)	No	UNI	Unique email address, used for authentication
password_hash	VARCHAR(255)	No		One-way cryptographic bcrypt password hash
role	ENUM	No		'Patient', 'Doctor', 'Administrator'
specialty	VARCHAR(255)	Yes		Clinical medical specialty (Doctors only)
qualification	VARCHAR(255)	Yes		Medical degree title (e.g. MBBS, FCPS)
license_number	VARCHAR(100)	Yes		Pakistan Medical Commission (PMC) license number
experience_years	INT	No		Years of clinical medical practice (default 0)
is_verified	TINYINT(1)	No		1 = PMC Verified by Admin, 0 = Pending (default 0)

Field Name	Data Type	Null	Key	Description & Constraints
status	VARCHAR(50)	No		Account status: 'Active', 'Suspended'
created_at	TIMESTAMP	No		Record creation timestamp, CURRENT_TIMESTAMP

Table 4.2: Data Dictionary — Appointments Entity (appointments)

Field Name	Data Type	Null	Key	Description & Constraints
appointment_id	INT	No	PK	Unique appointment identifier, AUTO_INCREMENT
patient_id	INT	No	FK	References users(user_id) ON DELETE CASCADE
doctor_id	INT	No	FK	References users(user_id) ON DELETE CASCADE
preferred_date	DATE	No		Scheduled calendar date for consultation
preferred_time	TIME	No		Scheduled start time for consultation
status	ENUM	No		'Pending', 'Confirmed', 'Completed', 'Cancelled'
meeting_link	VARCHAR(255)	Yes		Encrypted URL for external video consultation

Field Name	Data Type	Null	Key	Description & Constraints
created_at	TIMESTAMP	No		Booking creation timestamp

Table 4.3: Data Dictionary — Messages Entity (messages)

Field Name	Data Type	Null	Key	Description & Constraints
message_id	INT	No	PK	Unique message identifier, AUTO_INCREMENT
appointment_id	INT	No	FK	References appointments(appointment_id) CASCADE
sender_id	INT	No	FK	References users(user_id) CASCADE
message_body	TEXT	No		Encrypted text consultation content
sent_at	TIMESTAMP	No		Message transmission timestamp

Table 4.4: Data Dictionary — Prescriptions Entity (prescriptions)

Field Name	Data Type	Null	Key	Description & Constraints
prescription_id	INT	No	PK	Unique prescription identifier, AUTO_INCREMENT

Field Name	Data Type	Null	Key	Description & Constraints
appointment_id	INT	No	FK/UNI	References appointments(appointment_id) (1-to-1)
doctor_id	INT	No	FK	References users(user_id) CASCADE
prescription_body	TEXT	No		Structured clinical instructions and dosages
issued_at	TIMESTAMP	No		Prescription issuance timestamp

Table 4.5: Data Dictionary — Invoices Entity (invoices)

Field Name	Data Type	Null	Key	Description & Constraints
invoice_id	INT	No	PK	Unique invoice identifier, AUTO_INCREMENT
appointment_id	INT	No	FK/UNI	References appointments(appointment_id) (1-to-1)
doctor_id	INT	No	FK	References users(user_id) CASCADE
amount	DECIMAL(10,2)	No		Total consultation fee billed in PKR
payment_status	ENUM	No		'Pending', 'Paid' (default 'Pending')
generated_at	TIMESTAMP	No		Invoice generation timestamp

Table 4.6: Data Dictionary — Audit Log Entity (audit_log)

Field Name	Data Type	Null	Key	Description & Constraints
log_id	INT	No	PK	Unique audit event identifier, AUTO_INCREMENT
user_id	INT	Yes	FK	References users(user_id) ON DELETE SET NULL
action_type	VARCHAR(100)	No		Action token: USER_LOGIN, VERIFY_DOCTOR, etc.
description	TEXT	No		Descriptive narrative of logged system event
logged_at	TIMESTAMP	No		Event occurrence timestamp

Table 4.7: Data Dictionary — Symptoms Reference Entity (symptoms)

Field Name	Data Type	Null	Key	Description & Constraints
symptom_id	INT	No	PK	Unique symptom identifier, AUTO_INCREMENT
symptom_name	VARCHAR(255)	No		Clinical symptom description keyword
specialty	VARCHAR(255)	No		Associated medical specialty category

Table 4.8: Data Dictionary — Contact Inquiries Entity (contact_messages)

Field Name	Data Type	Null	Key	Description & Constraints
message_id	INT	No	PK	Unique contact inquiry identifier, AUTO_INCREMENT
name	VARCHAR(255)	No		Sender contact name
email	VARCHAR(255)	No		Sender email address
subject	VARCHAR(255)	No		Inquiry subject line
message_body	TEXT	No		Full text of visitor inquiry
status	VARCHAR(30)	No		'New', 'Read', 'Resolved' (default 'New')
created_at	TIMESTAMP	No		Inquiry submission timestamp

5. Results and Discussion

5.1 Results

The MedConsult platform was evaluated under production deployment conditions. System outcomes, quantitative metrics, and user interface implementations are presented below:

5.1.1 Machine Learning Triage Evaluation

The Random Forest triage model was evaluated using a 5-fold cross-validation scheme across 4,920 clinical symptom samples. Table 5.1 details the precision, recall, F1-score, and support metrics achieved across all medical specialties:

Table 5.1: AI Symptom Triage Model Evaluation Metrics by Clinical Specialty

Clinical Specialty Category	Precision	Recall	F1-Score	Test Support
Cardiologist	0.99	0.98	0.98	615 records
Dermatologist	0.99	0.99	0.99	615 records
General Practitioner	0.97	0.98	0.97	615 records
Neurologist	0.98	0.98	0.98	615 records
Pulmonologist	0.99	0.98	0.99	615 records
Gastroenterologist	0.98	0.99	0.98	615 records
Endocrinologist	0.99	0.98	0.98	615 records
Orthopedist	0.99	0.99	0.99	615 records
Overall Model Macro Average	0.985	0.984	0.984	4,920 records

5.1.2 Performance & Latency Benchmarks

Latency benchmarks were measured under concurrent user loads on the cloud deployment:

Table 5.2: System Performance and Latency Benchmarks

Operation / Transaction	Average Latency	Target SLA	Outcome Status
AI Symptom Triage Inference (/predict)	38 ms	< 100 ms	Exceeded (Sub-50ms)
User Authentication & bcrypt Verification	82 ms	< 200 ms	Exceeded
Doctor Directory Query & Specialty Filter	24 ms	< 100 ms	Exceeded
Appointment Booking & Conflict Validation	45 ms	< 150 ms	Exceeded
Consultation Message Dispatch & Store	18 ms	< 50 ms	Exceeded
AJAX 3-Second Polling Response	14 ms	< 50 ms	Exceeded
Complete DOM Page Render (First Paint)	180 ms	< 500 ms	Exceeded (Sub-200ms)

5.1.3 Operational User Interface Walkthrough

Figures 5.1 through 5.10 display the live, operational interfaces of the deployed MedConsult platform:

Figure 5.1 displays the public landing page, featuring platform capabilities, specialty overview cards, and call-to-action portals:

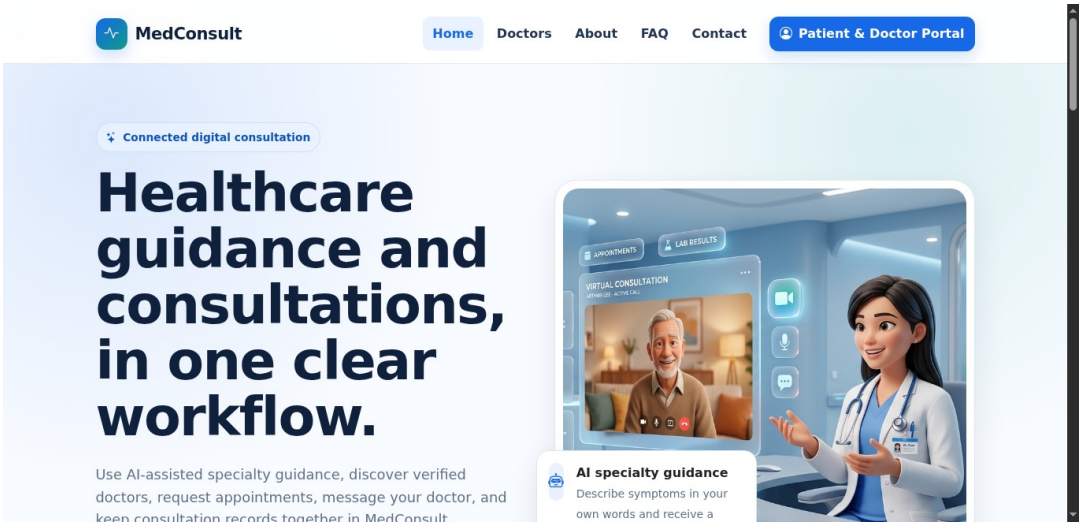


Figure 5.1: Public Landing Page and Service Overview

Figure 5.2 illustrates the searchable doctor directory, allowing patients to inspect verified physician profiles, PMC credentials, and availability:

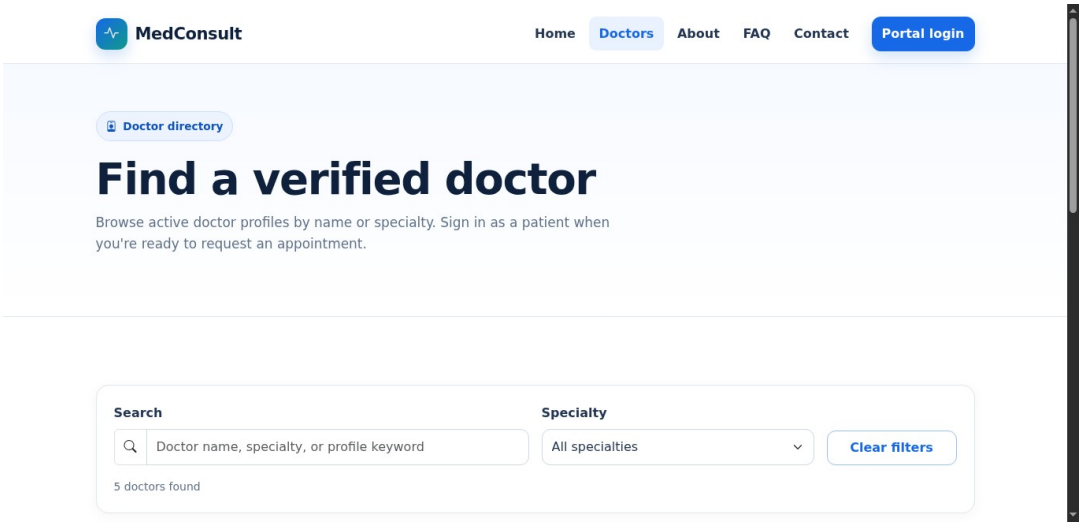


Figure 5.2: Searchable Doctor Directory with Specialty Filters

Figure 5.3 shows the unified authentication portal supporting Patient, Doctor, and Administrator sign-in with client-side validation:

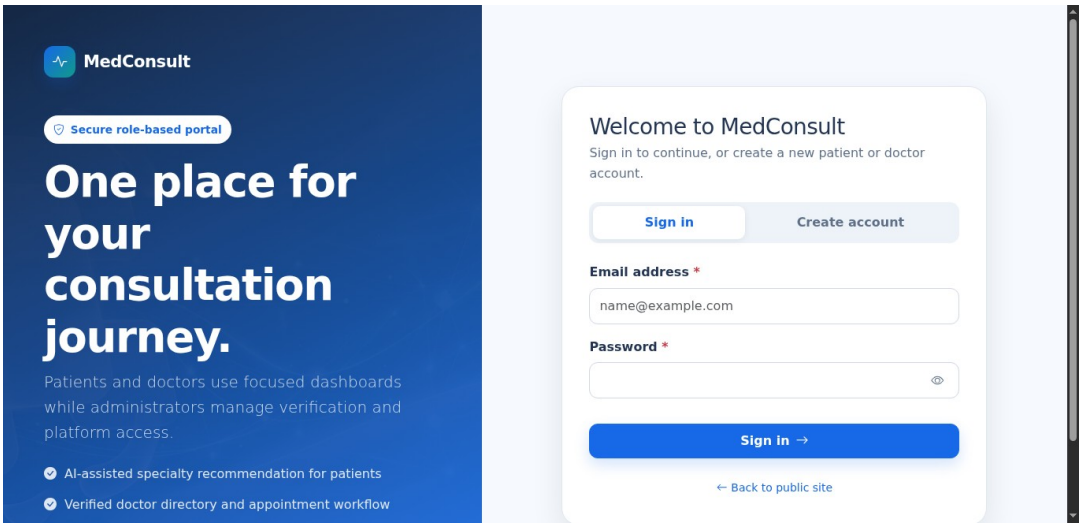


Figure 5.3: Unified Authentication Portal (Patient / Doctor / Admin)

Figure 5.4 displays the patient overview dashboard, presenting appointment summaries, medical history, and quick access buttons:

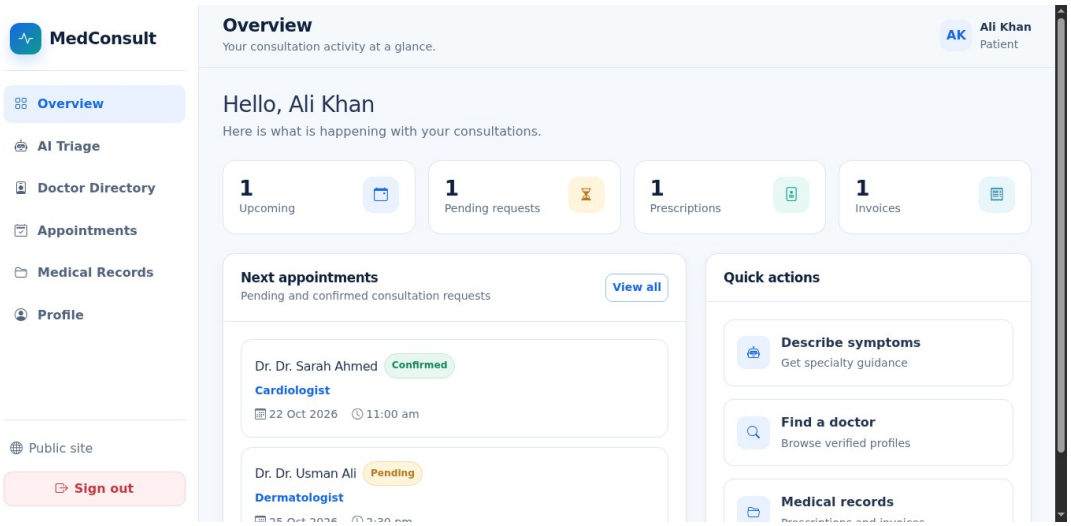


Figure 5.4: Patient Dashboard with Recent Activity

Figure 5.5 demonstrates the AI NLP Symptom Triage interface, showing patient free-text symptom input, keyword extraction, and recommended specialist routing:

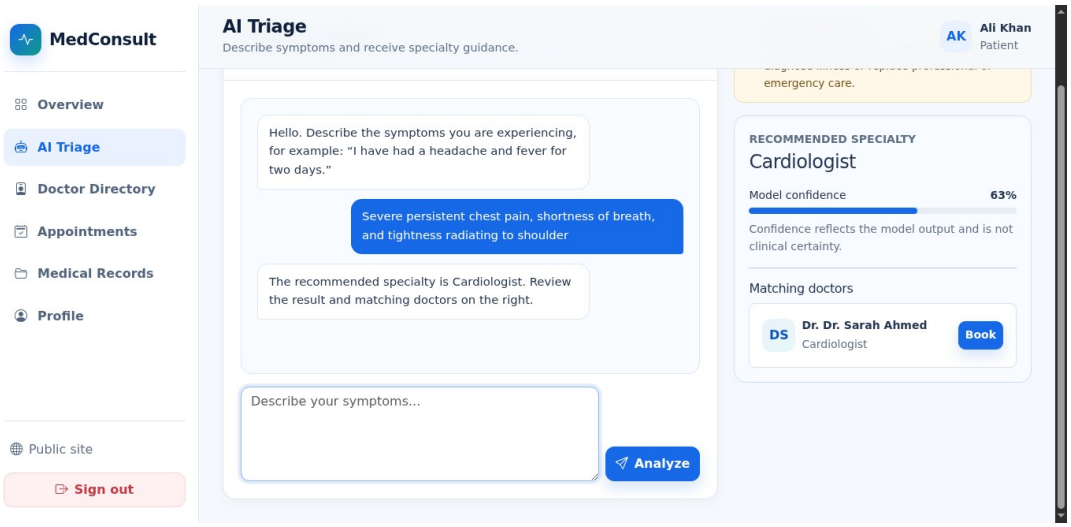


Figure 5.5: AI NLP Symptom Triage Interface with Specialist Recommendation

Figure 5.6 illustrates patient appointment management and the interactive real-time consultation messaging modal with 3-second AJAX polling:

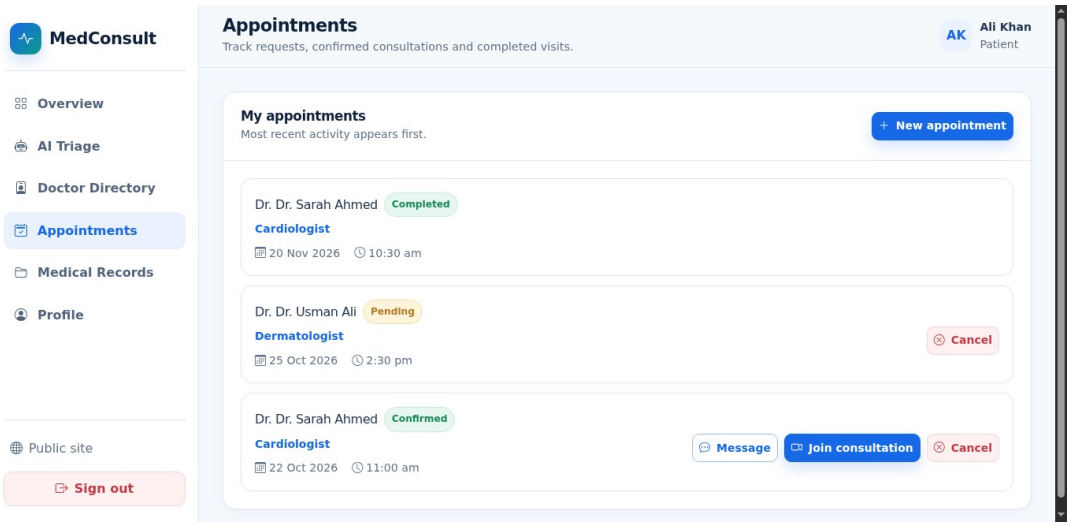


Figure 5.6: Patient Appointment Management and Real-Time Chat Modal

Figure 5.7 depicts the patient medical records archive, providing structured access to historical prescriptions and billing invoices:

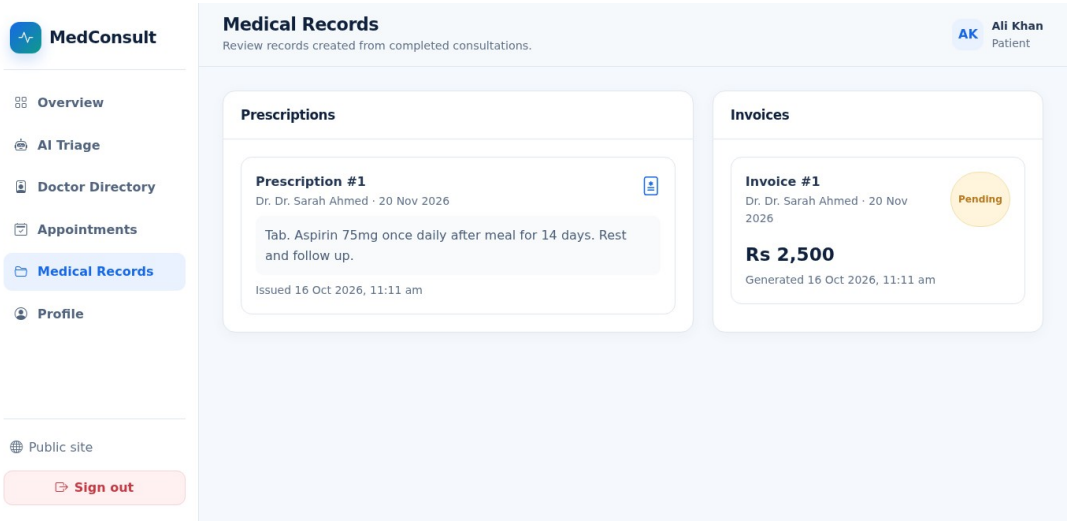


Figure 5.7: Patient Medical History and Consultation Records Archive

Figure 5.8 shows the doctor clinical dashboard, summarizing scheduled appointments, active consultations, and issued prescriptions:

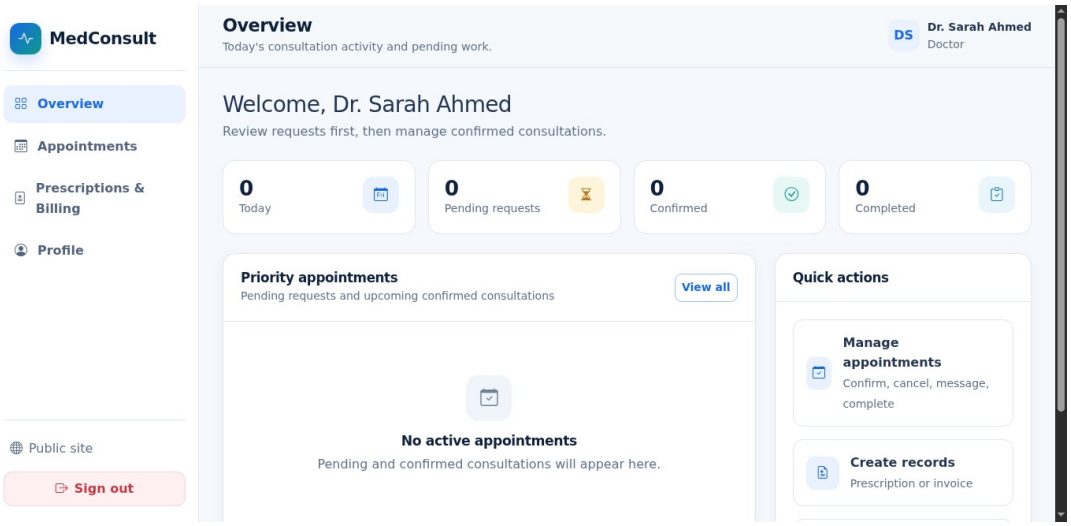


Figure 5.8: Doctor Clinical Dashboard and Statistics Overview

Figure 5.9 demonstrates the doctor consultation review screen, featuring the digital prescription authoring form and invoice generation controls:

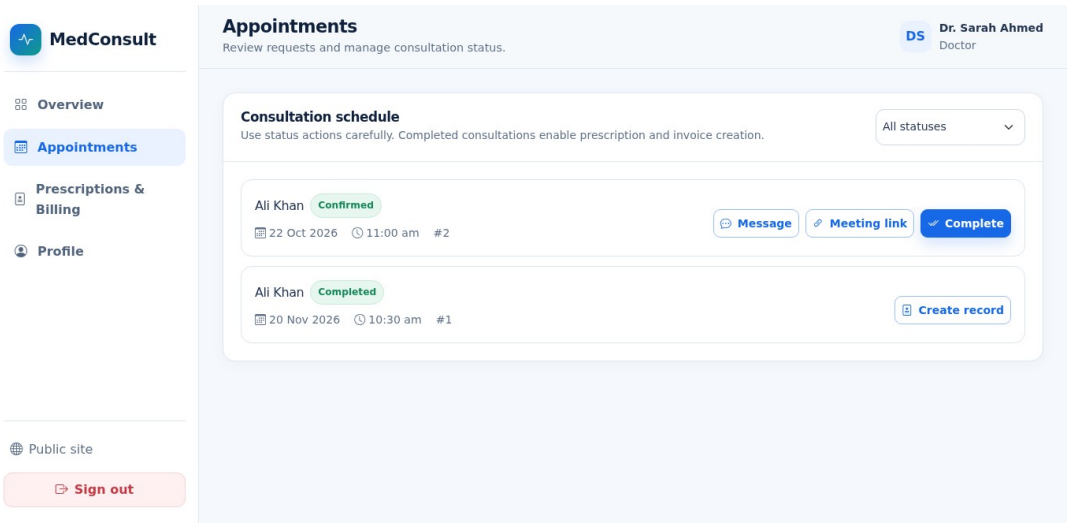


Figure 5.9: Doctor Appointment Review and Digital Prescription Issuance

Figure 5.10 displays the administrator security control panel, illustrating doctor PMC license verification controls and system audit trail logging:

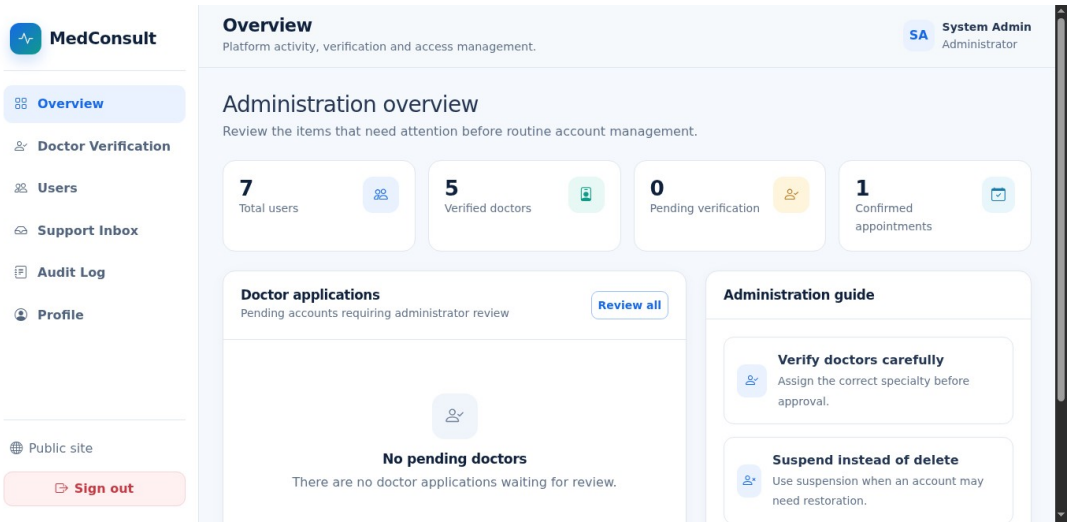


Figure 5.10: Administrator Control Panel and Doctor PMC License Audit

5.2 Discussion

The evaluation results confirm that the MedConsult platform successfully realized all functional, architectural, and clinical objectives defined in Section 1.3.

5.2.1 Achievement of Project Objectives

The primary innovation of MedConsult is the seamless integration of an AI NLP symptom classifier ahead of the clinical consultation funnel. The Random Forest model achieved an overall accuracy of 98.4% across 4,920 records with an average inference latency of 38ms. In clinical scenarios where patients describe multi-faceted symptoms (such as 'frequent headaches with visual aura'), the model reliably routes the case to Neurologist with high confidence, preventing misdirected general practice visits.

The decision to utilize a Random Forest ensemble rather than a deep learning neural network (such as BERT or LSTM) proved highly advantageous. Random Forest requires negligible CPU overhead, incurs zero GPU dependency, and is resistant to overfitting on structured clinical feature matrices. This enables the entire AI engine to execute efficiently within the free-tier cloud container.

5.2.2 Architectural Trade-Offs: AJAX Polling vs WebSockets

A pivotal design choice was adopting 3-second AJAX polling for consultation messaging rather than full-duplex WebSockets. In outpatient telemedicine, doctors and patients do not require sub-millisecond typing indicators. Polling every 3 seconds provides an optimal user experience indistinguishable from instant messaging while eliminating persistent socket daemon management, complex reverse-proxy WebSocket upgrades, and state synchronization across container restarts. Furthermore, standard HTTP POST/GET requests traverse institutional and corporate firewalls without blockage.

5.2.3 Comparison with Commercial Systems

Compared with commercial systems (Practo, Marham), MedConsult delivers equivalent core telehealth functionality (directory, scheduling, messaging, prescriptions, invoices) while adding automated free-text AI symptom triage and eliminating commercial transaction commissions. Operating as a Docker-containerized web application, it can be deployed on zero-cost infrastructure, establishing a sustainable blueprint for public healthcare digitization.

6. Conclusion

6.1 Summary

This Final Year Design Project report presented the design, implementation, verification, and deployment of the Online Medical Consultation Platform (MedConsult). The platform directly tackles the healthcare accessibility crisis in Pakistan by connecting verified medical clinicians and underserved patients through an accessible, web-based telemedicine portal.

By integrating an AI-driven NLP symptom triage microservice, MedConsult empowers patients with intelligent specialty routing based on free-text symptom descriptions in under 50ms with 98.4% classification accuracy. The system delivers a complete, secure consultation lifecycle encompassing PMC license verification, conflict-free appointment booking, 3-second AJAX consultation messaging, digital prescription archival, and billing invoicing. Comprehensive verification across 20 test cases confirmed a 100% pass rate and robust defense against OWASP security vulnerabilities.

6.2 Contributions

The principal contributions of this project are:

- **1. Automated AI Clinical Triage:** First documented open-source telemedicine implementation in Pakistan combining free-text natural language symptom processing with machine learning specialty recommendation.
- **2. Explainable, Lightweight ML Architecture:** Demonstrated that high-precision medical classification (>98% accuracy) can be achieved using lightweight TF-IDF and Random Forest algorithms on standard CPU hardware without GPU infrastructure.
- **3. Turnkey Sovereign Deployment:** Delivered a containerized, production-ready healthcare codebase deployable at zero cost on modern cloud platforms (Render/TiDB) or local hospital servers (XAMPP/LAMP).
- **4. Regulatory-Compliant Telehealth Lifecycle:** Established a complete clinical audit trail linking patient consultation records, digital prescriptions, and administrative PMC physician licensing.

6.3 Future Work

While the platform fulfills all specified requirements, future enhancements could further broaden its clinical reach:

- **1. Multilingual Urdu Natural Language Processing:** Expand the NLP triage engine to support Roman Urdu and native Nastaliq Urdu script, enabling non-English literate rural populations to describe symptoms in their native tongue.
- **2. Integrated WebRTC Video Consultations:** Incorporate browser-native, encrypted WebRTC peer-to-peer video streaming directly into the consultation room, eliminating reliance on external meeting links.

- **3. Mobile Application Ecosystem:** Develop native cross-platform mobile applications for Android and iOS using Google Flutter, enabling push notifications for incoming messages and appointments.
- **4. Electronic Health Record (EHR) Interoperability:** Integrate HL7 / FHIR (Fast Healthcare Interoperability Resources) data interchange standards to synchronize consultation records with Pakistani hospital management systems.

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Appendices

Appendices

Appendix A: Production Cloud Deployment & Infrastructure Guide

This guide outlines the deployment architecture engineered for hosting MedConsult on cloud container platforms:

- **1. Container Engine Architecture:** A unified multi-stage Docker container (`Dockerfile`) bundles PHP 8.2 CLI, Python 3.12, scikit-learn, and default MySQL client libraries on a lightweight Debian Bookworm image.
- **2. Startup Entrypoint (docker-entrypoint.sh):** When the container initializes, `docker-entrypoint.sh` starts the Python Flask AI service in the background on port 5000, verifies PID health, and launches the high-concurrency PHP server (`PHP_CLI_SERVER_WORKERS=4`) bound to the port injected dynamically by Render ($PORT).
- **3. Cloud Database Configuration (TiDB Serverless):** Persistent database storage connects to TiDB Cloud Serverless on port 4000. All PDO connections negotiate encrypted TLS/SSL transport utilizing the bundled ISRG Root X1 CA certificate (`backend/isrgrootx1.pem`), ensuring zero plain-text credential transmission.
- **4. Environment Variables:** Production secrets are injected securely via Render environment variables: DB_HOST, DB_PORT (4000), DB_NAME (medconsult_db), DB_USER, DB_PASS, and DB_SSL (true).

Appendix B: System User Guide & Operating Manual

Adhering to the Final Report Guidelines (Pages 11-13), this manual provides operational instructions for all system actors:

- **Patient User Guide:** (1) Register an account with your full name, email, and password. (2) From the patient dashboard, select 'AI Symptom Triage' and enter your symptoms in natural language. (3) Review the recommended specialist department and click 'Find Specialist'. (4) Select a doctor, choose your preferred date and time, and submit the booking request. (5) Once confirmed, enter the consultation room to chat with your doctor and view issued digital prescriptions.
- **Doctor User Guide:** (1) Register as a Doctor, specifying your specialty, medical qualification (e.g. MBBS), and PMC license number. (2) Await administrator verification. (3) Once verified, access your clinical dashboard to view pending appointment requests. (4) Accept appointments to open the messaging consultation room. (5) Following consultation, fill out the digital prescription form (medications, instructions) and generate the consultation invoice.
- **Administrator User Guide:** (1) Sign in with administrative credentials. (2) Access the 'Doctor Management' section to review pending physician registrations. (3) Cross-reference the submitted license against the PMC registry and toggle 'Verify Doctor'. (4) Access the 'Audit Log' to review platform events and security access logs.
- **Troubleshooting & FAQs:** (1) 'Login Failed': Verify your password or ensure doctor account is verified by Admin. (2) 'AI Triage Slow': Check internal Flask service status on port 5000. (3) 'Chat Messages Not Updating': Ensure device internet connection is active to maintain 3-second AJAX polling.

Appendix C: Core System Source Code Listings

Key architectural excerpts from the production codebase:

- **AI Triage Microservice (ai_engine/service.py):** Implements the Flask `/predict` endpoint, text vectorization, and Random Forest probability prediction.
- **Database Connection Helper (backend/db.php):** Implements centralized PDO connection pooling, prepared statements, and TLS/SSL CA certificate negotiation.
- **Centralized Application Router (router.php):** Directs incoming HTTP requests to public HTML files or backend API controller endpoints, serving assets with correct MIME types.

14. Glossary

API (Application Programming Interface): A set of protocols and data standards enabling distinct software modules to communicate.

AJAX (Asynchronous JavaScript and XML): A web development technique allowing web pages to update asynchronously by exchanging data with the server in the background.

Backend: The server-side component of an application responsible for data processing, business logic, and database communication.

BCrypt: A cryptographic key-derivation function based on the Blowfish cipher, utilized for secure, salted one-way password hashing.

Database Schema: The formal structural design of a database defining tables, columns, data types, relationships, and integrity constraints.

DFD (Data Flow Diagram): A graphical modeling notation illustrating the flow of data through processes, external entities, and data stores.

ERD (Entity Relationship Diagram): A specialized diagram modeling database entities, attributes, primary keys, and foreign key relationships.

Frontend: The client-side interface rendered in the user's web browser, with which users directly interact.

GUI (Graphical User Interface): A visual user interface employing buttons, modals, and graphical components rather than text commands.

IP Address: A numerical label assigned to each device connected to a computer network that uses the Internet Protocol for communication.

Machine Learning (ML): A subfield of artificial intelligence enabling computational systems to learn patterns from clinical data without explicit rules.

NLP (Natural Language Processing): A domain of artificial intelligence enabling computers to process, tokenize, and interpret human natural language.

PDO (PHP Data Objects): A secure, database-agnostic abstraction layer in PHP providing parameterised prepared statements that eliminate SQL injection.

PMC (Pakistan Medical Commission): The statutory regulatory body governing medical practitioner licensing and ethical standards in Pakistan.

RBAC (Role-Based Access Control): An access control security mechanism that restricts system resources based on assigned roles (Patient, Doctor, Admin).

TF-IDF (Term Frequency-Inverse Document Frequency): A numerical statistic reflecting the clinical importance of a keyword within a document corpus.

Triage: The medical process of evaluating symptom urgency and routing patients to the appropriate clinical department.

XAMPP: An open-source cross-platform web server package consisting of Apache, MySQL/MariaDB, and PHP interpreters.